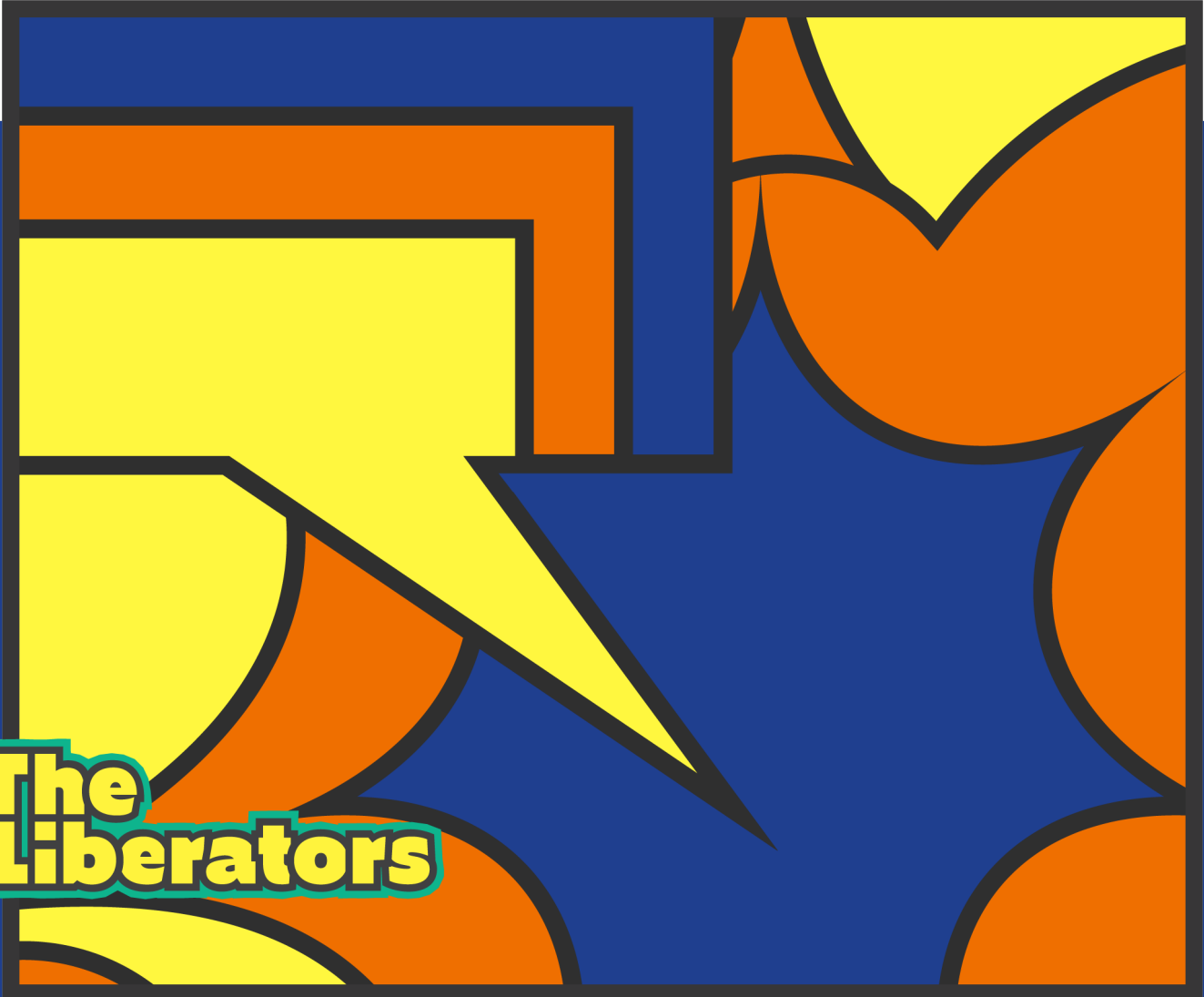


Build Psychological Safety With Appreciative Interviews

A do-it-yourself workshop to reinvigorate your team and its members by exploring what made them successful in the past



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

From our research, we know that psychological safety is one of the most important contributors to successful teams. [Amy Edmondson](#), professor of Leadership and Management, defines psychological safety as "as a shared belief about the consequences of interpersonal risk-taking".

You can encourage psychological safety by inviting people to connect on a personal level, rather than just as professionals. Psychological safety is not about always agreeing with each other, or about giving compliments all the time. It is much more about encouraging people to speak up when they have worries, uncertainties, or doubts.

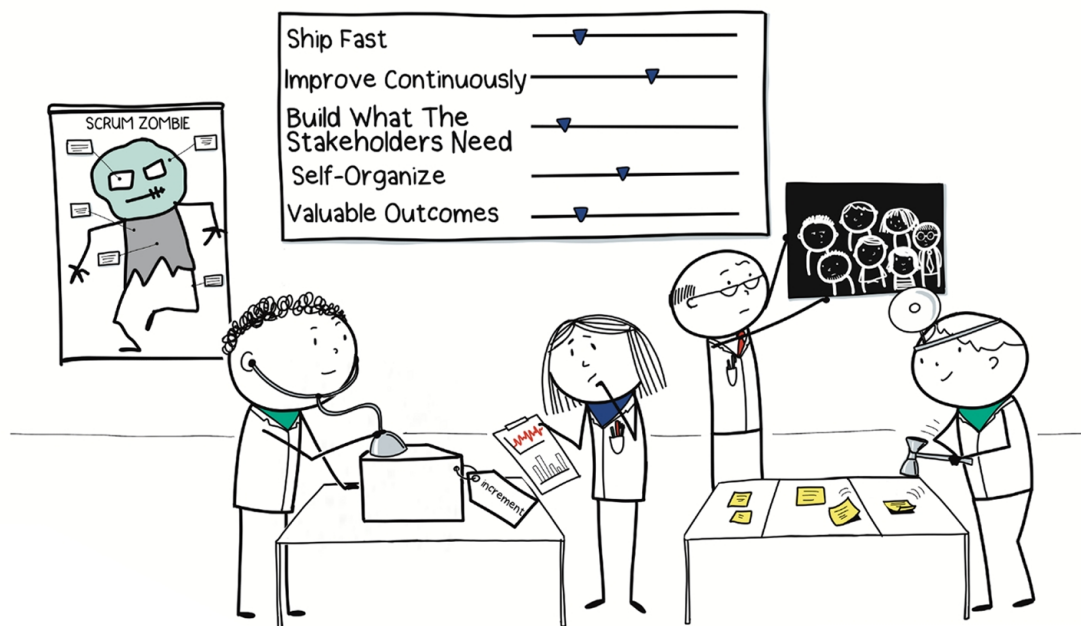
So what can you do to increase psychological safety? We've found this string of Liberating Structures to be very useful. In it, you ask people to remember the successes of their team – both large and small. When people have shared a personal story, everyone has the opportunity to share a personal challenge they would like to get help with, to make this team more successful.

You'll find that each structure is essentially about personal stories rather than abstract concepts. This already increases safety, trust, and offers a common ground to build on. It's up to each participant to decide how personal they want the stories to be.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 2 min

Step 2: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews

  35 min

Step 3: Give & Get Help With Troika Consulting

  35 min

Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  15 min

Step 5: Closing

 3 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



The Liberating Structures of this string, are straight-forward and easy to use.

Impact On Survival



The psychological safety created with this string is essential in resolving tension, conflict, and impediments.



How To Prepare

Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

You can run this string with pretty much any audience. Although the invitations and steps for this particular string are aimed at Scrum teams. You can also invite important stakeholders who frequently collaborate with the team to bring fresh perspectives on what made the team successful in the past.

Virtual Delivery

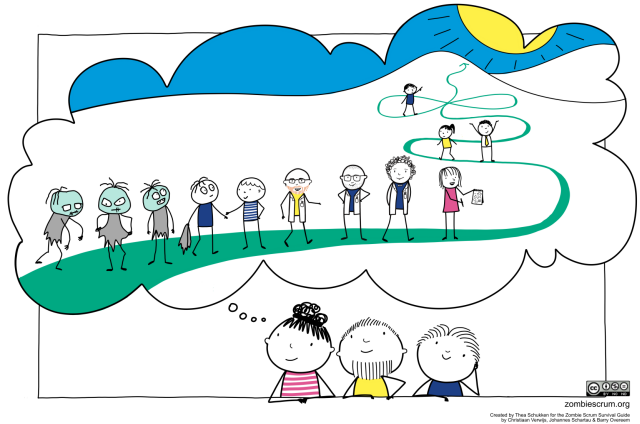
Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Material

- Optionally, get a [Scrum Team Starter Kit](#)

Resources

- Blog post: [How To Kickstart A Great Scrum Team](#)
- Blog post: [Is Your Scrum Team a Set of Pawns or Players?](#)
- Blog post: [Our 10 Tips to Have Productive and Engaging Virtual Meetings](#)



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast! We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews

We've found that it works best if you build personal connections from what people are proud of, or have warm memories about. The Liberating Structure [Appreciative Interviews](#) is a great way to do this.

Invitation

In pairs, share a story of a time when you were proud of what you did as a team. What did the team do? How did you contribute? What made the success possible?



Steps

1. **2 min** Explain the sequence of steps upfront so that people know they will be sharing a story, listening to another story, and then re-telling the story they listened to.
2. **2 min** Give participants a few minutes to silently bring back into memory a success story from their past, or at least the start of it.
3. **8 min** Invite pairs into their own breakouts. In turn (4 min each), people interview each other about the success story of the other while paying attention to what made the success possible. The interviewer only asks questions (no advice, suggestions, etc.).
4. **12 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. Everyone retells the story of the person they interviewed. The other three participants listen for patterns in conditions/assets that supported the success. Invite groups to capture the most salient factors in your virtual whiteboard.
5. **4 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect insights from the group. Ask people to share some examples of what created the insights for them. The purpose here is not to collect everything, but mostly to spread ideas around. So don't let this go on and on.
6. **4 min** Ask: "What was made possible by sharing our stories in this manner?". Invite people to silently reflect on this individually (1 minute) and then together.

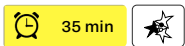
Our findings

- We often encourage people to channel a journalist that they admire or frequently read articles from in the newspaper. Frequently, this makes people ask deeper questions.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Discovering and Building on the Root Causes of Success with Appreciative Interviews](#)

- The original article on [Appreciative Interviews](#) on the website of Liberating Structures



Step 3: Give & Get Help With Troika Consulting



Now that people have shared personal stories, built interpersonal trust, and identified important success factors, we will build on this by inviting everyone to identify a personal challenge that is related to one of the factors.

[Troika Consulting](#) is a very useful Liberating Structure that allows people to ask for help once while giving it twice. It is one of those structures that evoke many

smiling faces *and* helpful suggestions.

Invitation

"If you consider what made our team successful in the past, what is a personal challenge that you face that – when addressed well – would make you and this team more successful in the future?"

Steps

1. Explain the steps. Troika Consulting takes three rounds. Everyone will be a "Client" once, with the other two acting as "Consultants".
2. **1 min** Ask everyone to think of a personal challenge they'd like to get help on from their peers. It is up to participants to decide how personal they want to make it.
3. **1 min** Invite people into breakouts of three participants each.
4. **2 min** Round one starts with the first client sharing his or her question in more detail. Consultants ask only clarifying questions.
5. **5 min** Ask the client to turn off their webcam and mute their microphone. Talking only to each other, the consultants generate ideas, suggestions, and coaching advice. In the meantime, the client listens and takes notes.
6. **2 min** The client turns their webcam and microphone back on and shares what was most insightful to them.
7. Groups switch to the next person and repeat the steps.
8. **5 min** Debrief what the experience was like. This is a good opportunity to emphasize that you'll offer much more of these experiences with this meetup.

Our Findings

- Create an overview of the instructions on your virtual whiteboard. People can use this as a reference once they are in their breakouts. Let people self-manage their timeboxes. If you can, broadcast every now and then what round people should be in.
- If the size of your group is not divisible by three, you can create one or two groups of four participants. In those groups, the extra person can give help twice but unfortunately won't be able to get help on their challenge. Ask for volunteers (e.g. people who don't have a clear challenge or don't mind not getting help on their challenge now).

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Troika Consulting
- How to use [Troika Consulting virtually](#)

Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

After User Experience Fishbowl, the heads of your participants are probably brimming with ideas and next steps – especially for those in a management position. The Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is useful to capture the next steps from a personal perspective.

Invitation

"Regardless of your role, what is a personal 15% Solution that you can take to make this team more successful? Where are do you have the autonomy and the resources to offer support?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partners find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **5 min** With the whole group, ask for the most important 15% Solutions that were identified. If you want, capture them on a shared surface.

Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

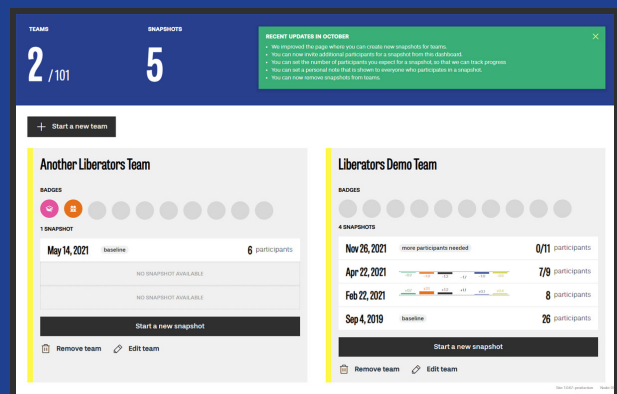
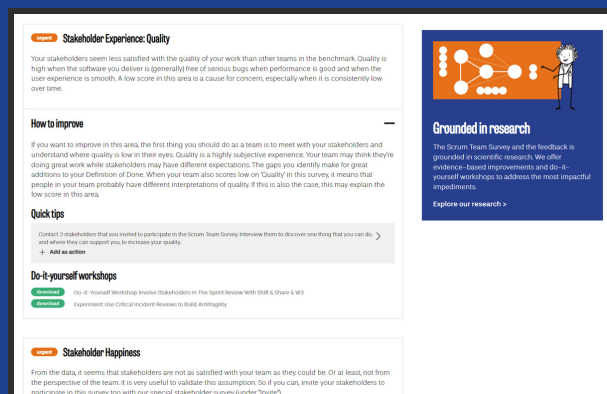
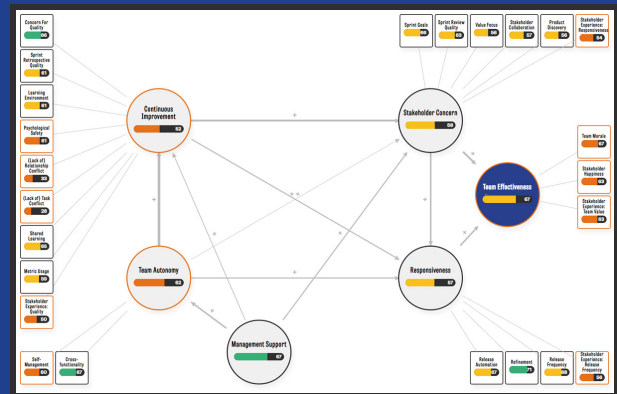
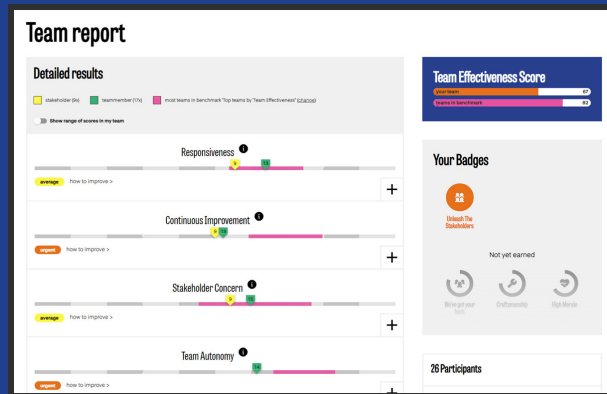
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
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Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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